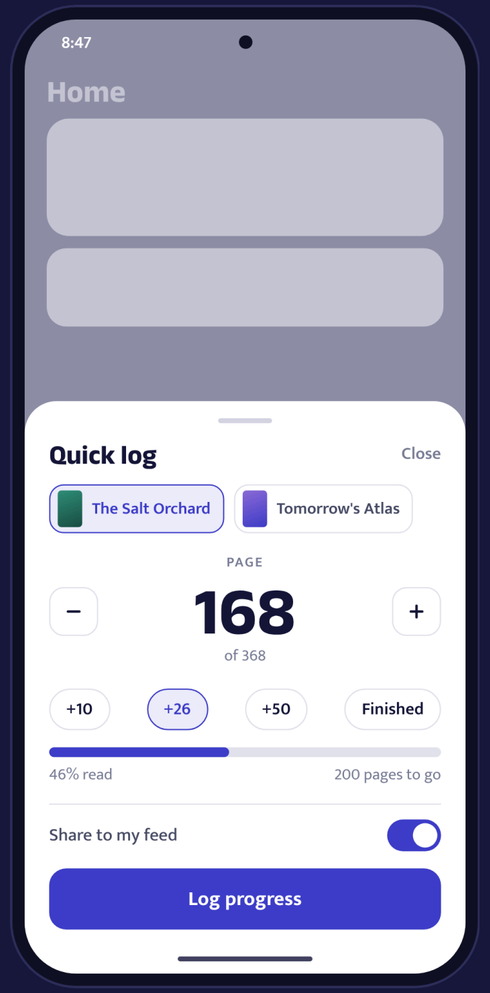
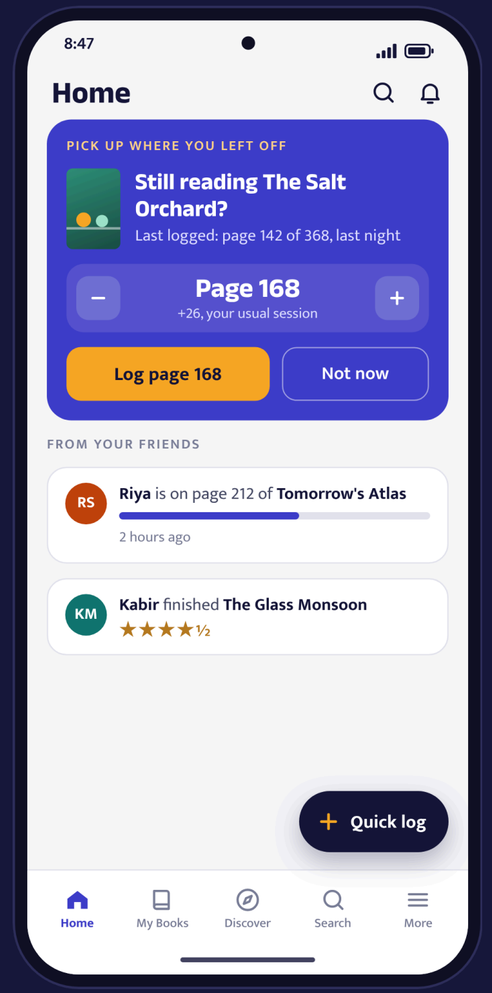
PRODUCT TEARDOWN · GOODREADS

Readers lose the moment

Why Goodreads readers stop logging their progress, and how a well-timed Quick Log could bring them back





PRODUCT
Goodreads mobile app

LENS
UX, growth and business model

DATE
October 2026

BY
Astha Purohit

Independent analysis. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Goodreads or Amazon.

AT A GLANCE

The teardown in one slide

Everything on Goodreads runs on logging, yet logging feels like admin work. Readers don't forget to log; they lose the moment.

WHAT I LOOKED AT

The Goodreads app end to end, from sign-up to shelves, plus its business model, its 2025–26 releases and four rival apps.

WHAT I FOUND

The urge to log comes back when readers open the app. The app greets them with popular lists and a feed, not their book.

WHAT I'D DO

Quick Log at the right moment: a card on app open, pre-filled with the likely page, plus a log button two taps from anywhere.

150M+
Members, September 2023

0 of 8
2025–26 releases that make logging faster

10 vs 4
Quick Log's priority score vs the next idea

3 → 1
Taps to log progress, with the prompt

CONTEXT

A social catalog for readers

Goodreads is a social cataloging platform. Readers track books, share reviews and find recommendations through community ratings and algorithms.

GOODREADS' MISSION

> **“Our mission is to help readers discover books they love and get more out of reading.”**

The promise I held it to: help readers find, and talk about, books they love.

2007
Launched in January

2013
Bought by Amazon

150M+
Members by September 2023

20B
Data points its recommendations analyze

Sources: Goodreads About page, 2026; Wikipedia, Goodreads (members as of September 2023)

HOW IT WORKS

Three engines, one loop

UTILITY

Catalog

Shelves for Want to Read, Currently Reading, Read and, since March 2026, Did Not Finish. Progress is logged by page or percent.

COMMUNITY

Social proof

Ratings add up to a community score that shapes what people buy. The feed shows what friends read: a book club at scale.

DATA

Recommendations

Collaborative filtering matches your shelves and ratings with similar readers. Kindle and Audible now feed in too.

THE NETWORK EFFECT

Logging is the input to all three engines.

You log a book → Friends see it → Recs sharpen → Shelves grow

BUSINESS MODEL

How Goodreads makes money

Advertising	Display ads in the app, plus sponsored emails and placements sold to publishers and authors.
Giveaways	Authors and publishers pay to give books away: $119 Standard or $599 Premium packages.
Buy links	A share of the sale when readers click through to a store to buy.
Amazon	Want to Read lists now link to Amazon shopping, and Goodreads ratings show on Kindle.

Sources: Book Riot, June 2022, updated December 2023; Goodreads announcements, February and March 2026

WHY LOGGING MATTERS

Every log is a feed post, a data point and a buying signal.

Feed post: more reasons to scroll, more ads seen.

Data point: sharper recommendations.

Buying signal: near the end of a book, a reader needs the next one.

RECENT RELEASES

What Goodreads shipped in 2025–26

Jul 2025 — TRACKING
Challenge achievements, new logo

Nov 2025 — AMAZON
Want to Read on Audible

Feb 2026 — AMAZON
Goodreads ratings on Kindle

Feb 2026 — AMAZON
Track 1M+ Audible audiobooks

Mar 2026 — AMAZON
Shop Want to Read on Amazon

Mar 2026 — TRACKING
Did Not Finish shelf

Aug 2026 — BUYING
Where to buy or borrow, iOS

Oct 2026 — RATING
Half-star ratings

5 of 8 releases tie Goodreads closer to Amazon and buying. None makes logging faster.

Tracking got broader: audiobooks, unfinished books, half stars. Logging speed wasn't on the list.

Sources: Goodreads blog, 14 July 2025 and 12 March 2026; Goodreads Help Center announcements, via Releasebot

USERS

Three kinds of readers

Goal-oriented achiever

20%
estimate

The power user. Tags everything and logs page by page, daily.

GOAL

Gamify reading and hit the yearly Reading Challenge

PAIN

Clunky screens make heavy data entry feel like admin

Needs speed: two taps from anywhere

Social scenester

30%
estimate

The trend seeker. Lives in Want to Read and reads friends' reviews first.

GOAL

Keep up with BookTok and what friends are reading

PAIN

A feed cluttered with ads, not friends' updates

Needs a reason: a log worth sharing

Passive tracker

50%
estimate

The Kindle native. Syncs from Kindle and rarely opens the app.

GOAL

A simple archive of everything read over the years

PAIN

The app feels too busy for such a small job

Needs zero effort: progress that syncs

Shares are my estimates, to check against real usage data.

JOURNEY

The reading loop, and where it breaks



WHERE IT BREAKS

Step 5 · Update progress

The only step that repeats many times per book, and each time it's typed by hand.

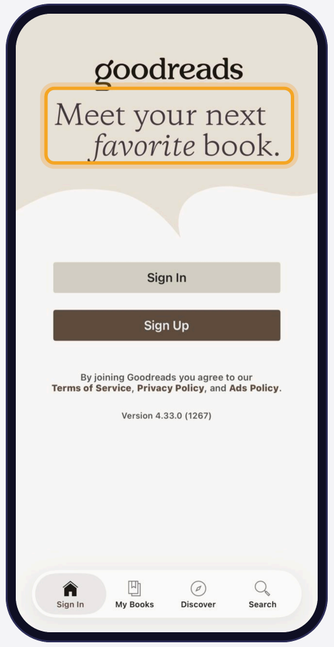
Step 1 · Discover

Lists favor what's already popular, so the loop restarts on the same books.

> **The highest friction sits in logging and discovery, which keeps daily use low.**

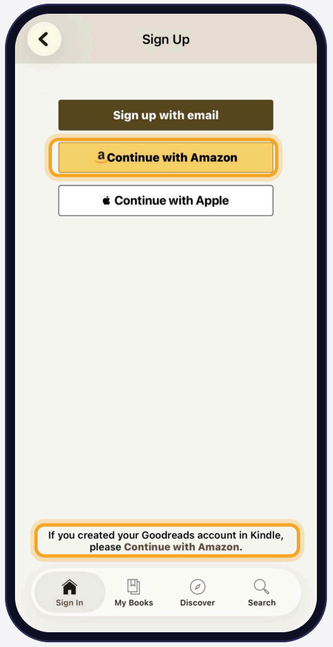
WALKTHROUGH · FIRST RUN

First run asks about your past



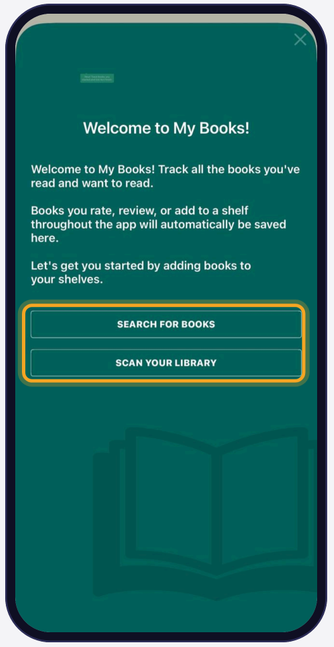
1 · Entry

The promise is discovery: “Meet your next favorite book.”



2 · Sign up

Amazon sits second, and Kindle accounts must use it.



3 · Shelf setup

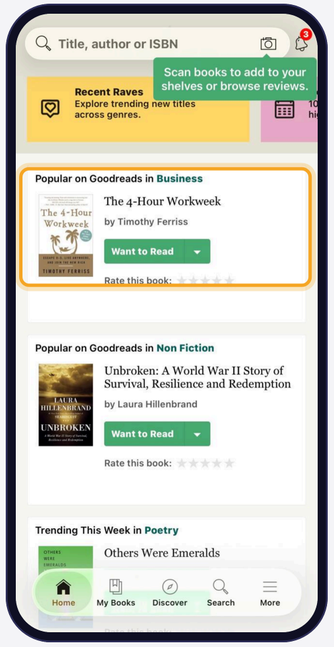
Setup asks you to add past reads: search or scan.

WHAT'S MISSING

None of these screens asks what you're reading now.

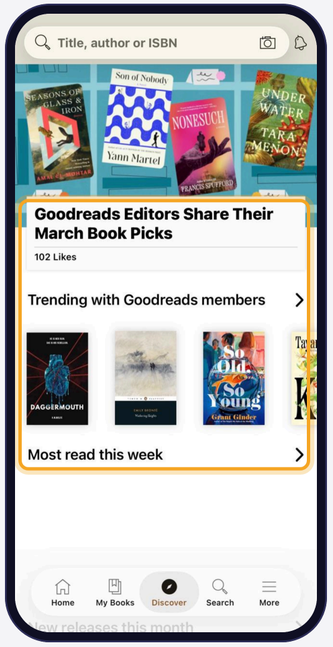
Currently Reading is the shelf that brings readers back daily. First run builds an archive instead.

Discovery leans on the crowd



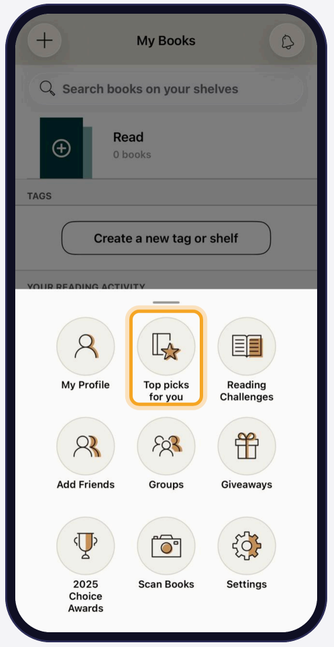
1 · Home

Home leads with popular picks. The Business one is from 2007.



2 · Discover

Editors' picks, trending and most read: lists for everyone.



3 · More

“Top picks for you”, the personal list, is one of nine tiles.

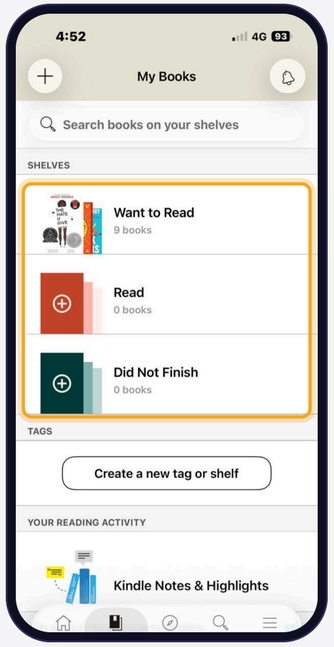
WHAT IT MEANS

Crowd lists get the best spots. Personal picks sit in a menu.

The popularity bias of collaborative filtering, visible on screen.

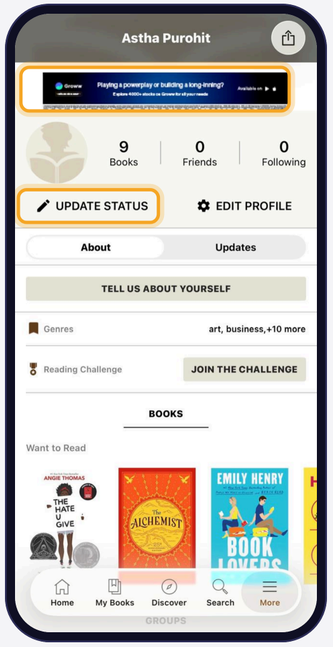
WALKTHROUGH · TRACKING

Logging sits in the back rooms



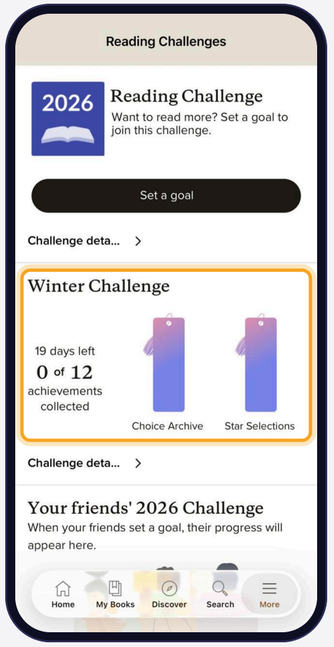
1 · My Books

With nothing in progress, Currently Reading isn't even listed.



2 · Profile

An ad tops my profile. Progress hides in “Update status”.



3 · Challenges

Goals and badges exist, but every one runs on logging.

WHAT IT MEANS

The motivation is built. The step that feeds it is buried.

Challenges and badges only move when readers log, the step that feels most like admin.

PAIN POINTS

Three pain points

Cognitive load of navigation

SITUATION

Wants to switch between their reading list and the feed.

ACTION

Digs through layered menus: nine tiles under More.

OUTCOME

Extra taps and clutter. They disengage.

Discovery dead-end

SITUATION

Wants fresh picks that match their taste.

ACTION

Gets older, high-volume popular books from the algorithm.

OUTCOME

Abandons discovery. The app feels stale.

“Admin work” burden

SITUATION

Wants to log progress or sort a book onto shelves.

ACTION

Fills in forms in a legacy mobile interface.

OUTCOME

It feels like data entry, not a reflection of their reading.

Why discovery stalls: collaborative filtering favors books many people have already rated, so niche and new titles surface less.

CORE INSIGHT

Readers don't forget to log. They lose the moment.

Reading is passive; logging is active. The urge to log comes back later, often while scrolling the feed, and the app gives it nowhere to go. That's a context gap, not just a UX problem.

AN ILLUSTRATIVE MORNING

10:40 PM

Puts the book down

Tired. Logging can wait until tomorrow.

→

8:47 AM · INTENT

Opens Goodreads

Remembers last night's pages. The urge to log is back.

→

8:48 AM

Scrolls the feed

Popular lists and posts. No sign of their book.

→

8:52 AM

Closes the app

Nothing logged. The moment has passed.

ASSUMPTIONS

What has to be true

MY ESTIMATE

60–70%

of readers log after a reading session, not during

How I'd check: compare log times with Kindle and Audible reading sessions.

MY ESTIMATE

~40%

drop off between the urge to log and logging

How I'd check: count app opens with a book in progress but no log that day.

MY ESTIMATE

<25%

of readers log progress daily

How I'd check: the share of weekly active readers who log on five or more days.

READERS HAVE SAID IT FOR YEARS · GOODREADS GROUP THREAD, 2013

> “I only update when I start and when I'm finished.”

> “I tend to update right after I put the book down each time I read.”

> “Only as often as I remember, which can be after a few pages or not until I've finished the book.”

COMPETITION

How rivals handle logging and discovery

APP	LOGGING	DISCOVERY	SOCIAL
Goodreads 150M+ members, 2023	Page or percent, typed by hand	Popular lists, editors, similar readers	Feed, groups, challenges
The StoryGraph ~4M users, early 2025	Charts on pace, mood and genre	Browse by mood and pace	Light: friends see finished books
Fable ~3M users, 2025	Page counts and reading stats	Trending titles, TikTok-led	100K+ book clubs, chapter chats
Hardcover Indie, founded 2021	Stats and custom tags	Explore by mood	Follow anyone's activity
Bookly Reading tracker	**A timer logs each session**	Not its focus	Goals and badges

The pattern: rivals lead on mood discovery and logging that feels rewarding. Goodreads leads on scale.

OPPORTUNITIES

Three pains, three ideas

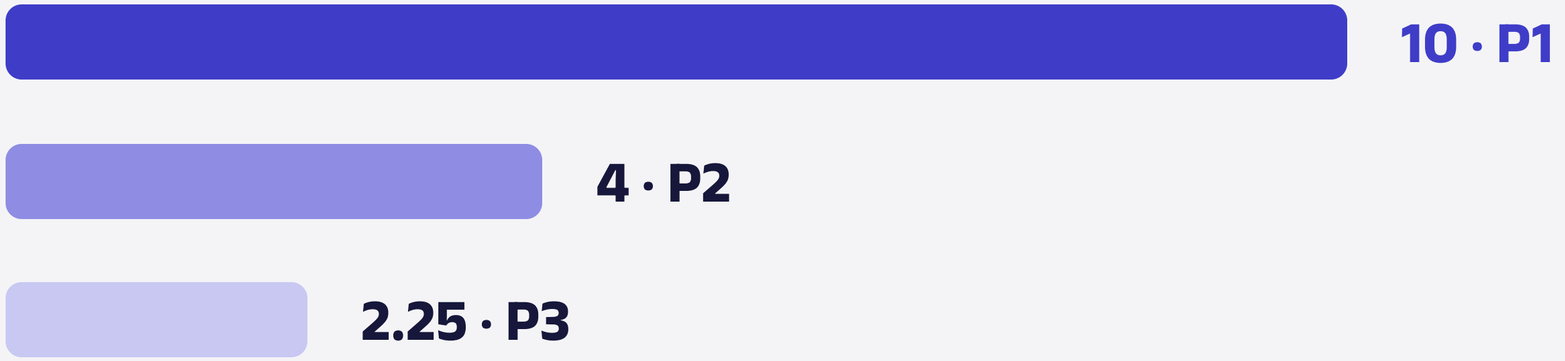
P1 **Clunky logging**	**Quick Log, well timed** A log button everywhere, plus a card that asks when you open the app.	If logging takes one tap instead of three, Currently Reading updates will rise sharply.
P2 **Cluttered feed**	**Smart Feed toggle** Switch the feed between friends only and recommended.	If readers can filter their feed, daily use rises as it gets more relevant.
P3 **Weak discovery**	**Mood filters** Browse by feel: fast-paced, thought-provoking, cozy.	If discovery matches how readers want to feel, they explore more and stay longer.

Quick Log and feed personalization tackle the most frequent friction with the least engineering effort.

PRIORITIZATION

What to build first

Priority = (Impact × Reach) ÷ Effort, each scored 1 to 5 by me



WHY QUICK LOG WINS

It speeds up the most frequent action in the app, with little engineering.

A NOTE ON MOOD FILTERS

StoryGraph and Hardcover already offer them. Build them to stop churn, not to stand out.

Log at the right moment

A prompt for the moment the urge returns, and a button for every other moment.

1. **Ask when intent is back**

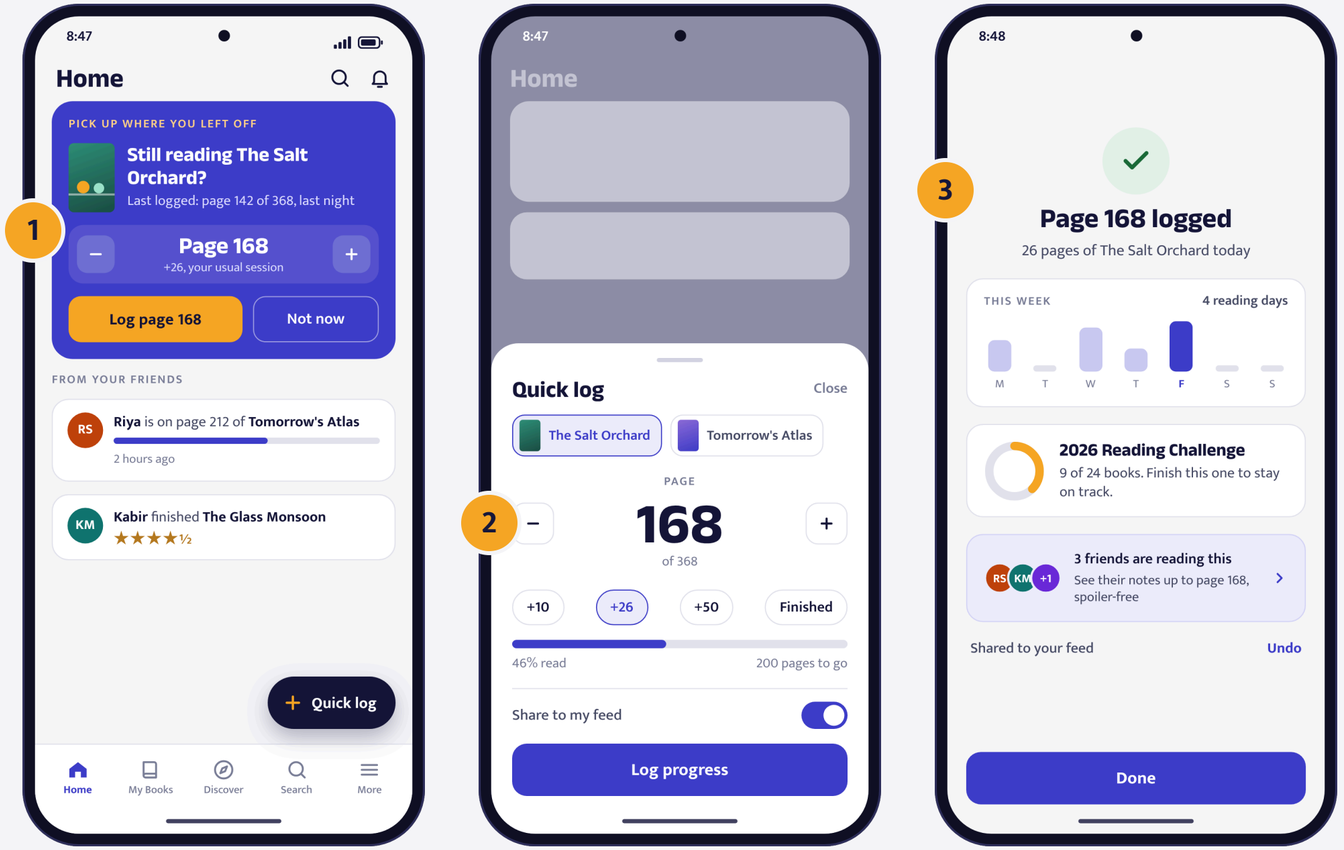
   On app open, a card names the book and pre-fills the likely page.

2. **Two taps from anywhere**

   The Quick log button opens one sheet: adjust the page, then log.

3. **Show that it counted**

   Pages today, the week and the challenge, with Undo one tap away.



THE BET · RULES

How the prompt decides

When it shows	On app open, if a book in progress has no log today and it's past your usual reading time.
What it pre-fills	Your last page plus your usual session; +20 pages for new readers; percent for e-books.
How often	Once a day at most, never as a push. Three “Not now” taps in a row pause it for a week.
Edge cases	Two books in progress: show the last one touched. “Finished” jumps to rating, half stars included.
First run	Setup asks what you're reading now, so the prompt has a book from day one.

WHO IT SERVES

Achiever

Two taps from anywhere, and the challenge moves.

Scenester

Each log can post to the feed, with spoiler-free notes.

Passive tracker

Later: progress that syncs from Kindle and Audible.

METRICS

How I'd measure it

NORTH STAR

Weekly logging readers: members who log progress at least once a week

PRIMARY

Share of Currently Reading books updated each week, logs per active reader, and prompt-to-log rate.

SUPPORTING

Daily active users, target +15% a year; Reading Challenge completion; likes on progress posts.

GUARDRAILS

Prompt dismissals, time in feed, ad views per session, and logs undone within a minute.

Test plan: four weeks, readers with a book in progress, three groups: today's app, the button alone, button plus prompt. Ship the prompt if it beats the button alone and the guardrails hold.

Later bets: new-reader churn −5% from asking for the current book at sign-up; search-to-shelf conversion +10% from mood filters.

REFLECTION

What I learned

1 · Match the fix to the insight

My first idea was a faster button. But my insight was about timing, so the fix needed a prompt at the moment the urge returns.

2 · Label what you assume

My usage numbers are estimates. Marking each one as an assumption, with a way to check it, made the case stronger, not weaker.

3 · Follow the loop to the money

Logging looked like a small UX fix. Tracing it through the feed, recommendations and the Amazon store showed why it matters.

4 · Read the release notes

Goodreads' 2025–26 releases showed where it is investing: Amazon tie-ins and tracking, not logging speed.

Next step: check the three assumptions against real usage data, then run the three-group test.

SOURCES

Sources and notes

Mission, launch date, recommendation data
Goodreads About page, 2026

Founding, Amazon deal, 150M+ members
Wikipedia, Goodreads (members as of Sept 2023)

Revenue streams and giveaway prices
Book Riot, June 2022, updated December 2023

New logo, achievements, audiobooks
Goodreads blog, 14 July 2025

Did Not Finish shelf
Goodreads blog, 12 March 2026

Other 2025–26 releases
Goodreads Help Center announcements, via Releasebot

The StoryGraph: users and mood features
We Are Founders, 17 February 2025

Fable: users and book clubs
Publishers Weekly, June 2025

Hardcover, Fable and StoryGraph features
SlashGear, 22 November 2024

Bookly's timer; member quotes
getbookly.com; Goodreads group thread, 2013

Screens are from my walkthrough of the Goodreads app (v4.33); the outlines are mine. Concept screens are my own designs with a made-up book. Shares and percentages are my estimates. Independent analysis, not affiliated with Goodreads or Amazon.

GOODREADS PRODUCT TEARDOWN

Thank you

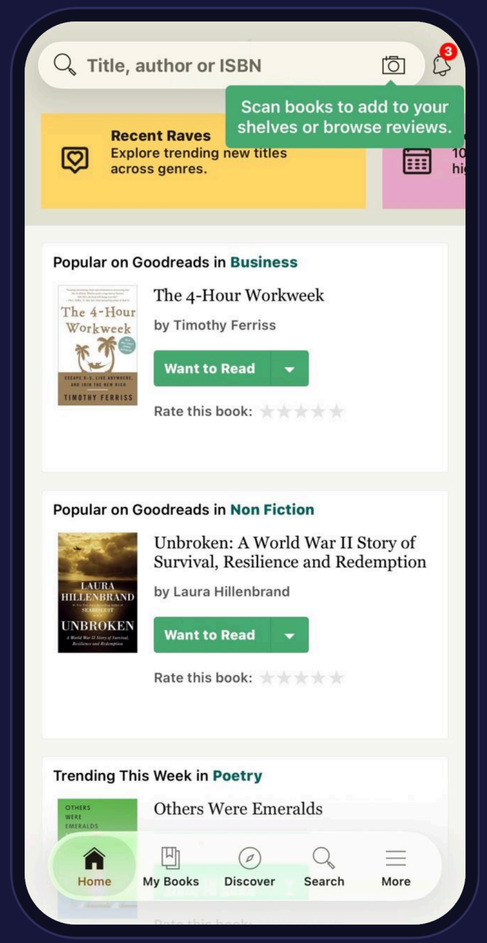
By shifting from a legacy book database to a personalized reading companion, Goodreads can bridge utility and community, and reclaim its place at the heart of reading.

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[LinkedIn URL] · [Portfolio URL]

TODAY



WITH QUICK LOG

